**STRICTER BANKRUPTCY LEGISLATION JUMPS SENATE HURDLE / SEE BELOW**

## Its own worst enemy

'Enemy at the Gates,' a free-range version of a true war story, never fully engages

**PREVIEW**

Cityside

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## Back on track

Wall Street regains composure after 3 days of volatile trading

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## Stanford blasts off

Cardinal romps to first-round NCAA Tournament win

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*"We're a small school . . . After tomorrow, people will know what St. Eliz is."*

**Eric Washington,** junior

## ST. ELIZABETH'S DAY TO SHINE

SEAN CONNELLY — Staff

**The St. Elizabeth High School Boys Basketball team asks for God's help during a pep rally Thursday as they prepare for the state title game today. It will be the first time the small school vied for the championship since 1996 and many said it will bring respect to the small school that has frequently been overshadowed by larger neighbors.**

# Small school plays big-time hoops

### Team with heart seeks state championship

**By Paul T. Rosynsky**
STAFF WRITER

*OAKLAND*

A TRIP by the St. Elizabeth High School boys basketball team to the state championship today represents more than just a successful athletic program.

It's a chance to upstage larger rival schools, send school pride skyrocketing and show others that size and resources don't match heart and will.

"We're a small school and people don't hear of us much," said junior Eric Washington, 16. "After tomorrow, people will know what St. Eliz is."

It is the smallest Catholic high school in the city, but one that both administrators and students agree has a lot of heart and a strong will to succeed.

Usually overshadowed by cross-town rival Bishop O'Dowd, Concord's De La Salle and Alameda's St. Joseph, 290-student St. Elizabeth goes largely unnoticed in the Fruitvale district, educating students who usually end up pursuing a college degree.

But at 4 p.m. today, the Cinderella-like Mustangs will shine in the spotlight as they play for the Division V state championship, despite being considered a sure first-round loser when the tournament began last month.

What got the team to the final game symbolizes the backgrounds and attitudes

Please see **Team,** NEWS-13

# On alert as supply dwindles

## Energy chief calls power blackouts 'inevitable'

ASSOCIATED PRESS

An unexpected drop in power imports from the Pacific Northwest and the shutdown of several in-state power generating facilities sent California into a Stage 2 alert Thursday.

The first Stage 2 alert since March 5 came as federal Energy Secretary Spencer Abraham warned power blackouts "appear inevitable" in California this summer and the state Assembly, reacting to suspicion that some power suppliers have shut down California plants this winter to raise prices, approved a proposal that would let state regulators fine generators that cannot justify their outages.

POWER CRISIS

The Independent System Operator called Thursday's alert as power reserves fell below 5 percent. The falling supply was due in part to the loss of at least

Please see **Power,** NEWS-13

## State utilities on brink of going broke

FROM STAFF, WIRE REPORTS

The possibility of bankruptcy for California's beleaguered electric utilities reared its head anew Thursday, thanks to a stalled legislative bill and an unfavorable federal court ruling that threatened to tip the delicate balance between debtors and creditors.

That might turn out to be good news in the long run, said one power watchdog.

Chances that alternative-energy producers might push Pacific Gas & Electric and Southern California Edison into involuntary bankruptcy grew Thursday when lawmakers acknowledged that a state Senate measure setting a payment schedule for debts owed to those producers has been stopped in its tracks, perhaps permanently.

Please see **Debts,** NEWS-13

# Senate OKs stricter bankruptcy rules

### Shielding assets, erasing debts targeted

**By Marcy Gordon**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The Senate voted Thursday to make it harder for people to erase their debts in bankruptcy courts and to close a loophole in present law that allows wealthy debtors to shield their assets in luxury homes.

The 83-15 vote in favor of the most sweeping overhaul of bankruptcy laws in 20 years occurred just two weeks after the House passed a similar bill, but one that left wealthy homeowners in some states protected.

The measure garnered the votes of 47 Republicans and 36 Democrats in the evenly divided Senate, while 13 Democrats and two Republicans opposed it. Sen. Peter Fitzgerald, R-Ill., voted present to avoid a conflict of interest because his family owns a bank.

Personal bankruptcy filings have declined in the past two years, but the legislation comes against the backdrop of a sagging economy and shaken stock market.

It was the second business-friendly measure to pass both houses of the new Congress. Last week, Congress voted to repeal workplace rules aimed at curbing repetitive motion injuries.

Please see **Rules,** NEWS-13

# Judicial victories, defeat in Raiders case

### Judge fines team, keeps city and county waiting

**By Robert Gammon**
STAFF WRITER

A Sacramento judge handed both the Oakland Raiders and the city of Oakland and Alameda County victories and defeats in a series of tentative legal rulings Thursday.

The city and county won when Sacramento County Superior Court Judge Joe Gray turned down the Raiders' request for an immediate judgment in favor of the team's claim it was tricked into returning to Oakland in 1995. Gray also refused to grant the Raiders' motion for steep economic sanctions against attorneys for the city and county.

Instead, the judge indicated he intends to fine the Raiders $1,200, saying the team filed part of its sanctions motion without justification.

The city and county lost, however, when the judge denied a separate motion to dismiss them from the case. Lawyers for the city and county had hoped for a repeat of an earlier victory, when the judge in December threw out fraud claims made by the Raiders.

Using the same argument, attorneys for the city and county said the Raiders' charges of breach of contract should be dismissed on the grounds that the team missed the statutory deadline for filing the lawsuit.

But Gray ruled against the city and county this time, saying the one-year statute of limitations did not apply because the

Please see **Raiders,** NEWS-13

**Inside**

▶ **NFL** says no payments to teams that move. **NEWS-2**

## GOOD MORNING


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# Vigilant search at S.F. airport for deadly foot-mouth disease

**By Justin Jouvenal**
STAFF WRITER

MILLBRAE — U.S. Department of Agriculture inspectors scrubbed shoes, ground fruit to a pulp and cooked meat here Thursday in an effort to keep a livestock disease from contaminating California that could cost ranchers millions.

Backed by a sign that read "Keep Foot-and-Mouth Disease OUT of America," the inspectors examined hundreds of suitcases of passengers arriving on non-stop flights from Great Britain. They looked for meat, fruit and shoes that might be contaminated with the disease.

Foot-and-mouth disease, which is harmless to humans, has ravaged livestock in England, where 215 separate outbreaks have been discovered since February. The USDA inspectors at SFO — and in airports around the country — are the front line in keeping the disease from spreading to the United States.

"We've done these inspections for years, but now we are stepping up our efforts," said Gary Smith, a USDA shift

Please see **Search,** NEWS-13

**USDA officer Sylvia Shadman-Adolpho scrubs the boot of an incoming traveler from England at San Francisco International Airport on Thursday.**

MATTHEW SUMNER — Staff